A PRACTICAL WHITE PAPER

The EDGE Framework

Clearer thinking, better decisions and effective execution

Evaluate. Define. Govern. Elevate.

A guide for leaders, teams and individuals who need to turn knowledge, experience and insight into action. Use it for a message, a commercial decision, a team priority or a wider business initiative.

Created by Adrian Watkins

I created EDGE to bring together the work of understanding a situation, choosing a direction, acting with confidence and learning from what happens. My experience across commercial operations, people, products and governance has shaped the questions in this guide.

Start with one real decision
By the end of this guide, you should be able to explain your choice, name the person who will act, identify the conditions for proceeding and set a useful review point.

INSIDE

The method and four pillars 02-06
Two worked illustrations 07-08
Reusable decision worksheet 09
Team use, tools and review 10-12
AI transformation illustration 13

Practical edition 3.2 | October 2026
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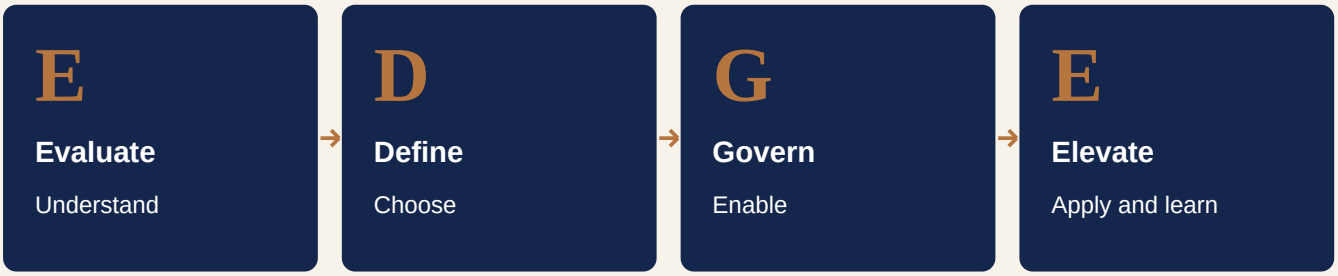

Carry what you learn into the next stage. Return when the context changes.

One sequence that carries learning forward

Start at Evaluate for a complete decision. Use a single pillar when the immediate need is clear.

EDGE provides a common structure. The depth should match the consequence, uncertainty and reversibility of the decision. A routine message may need a few thoughtful minutes. A market entry or integration may need evidence from several teams.

EVALUATE

Understand the situation. Carry forward evidence, context and the uncertainties that matter.

DEFINE

Choose the outcome and direction. Carry forward priorities, an owner and a practical next step.

GOVERN

Make decision rights and boundaries clear. Carry forward the conditions for confident execution.

ELEVATE

Act, review and improve. Carry forward what worked, what changed and what others can reuse.

You can enter at Govern to clarify an existing approval, or at Define to sharpen a message. Bring the relevant context from earlier stages. If the purpose or evidence is unclear, return to Evaluate rather than filling gaps with assumptions.

Governance is present throughout
Consider responsibilities and boundaries from the outset. The Govern stage formalises them around the chosen direction. It should help people know what they can do without another meeting.

EDGE organises thinking and action. It does not validate evidence for you or guarantee an outcome. Use relevant professional expertise where the decision requires it.

Evaluate

What decision are we really making, and what do we know?

Begin with the situation rather than a preferred solution. Write the decision as a question that someone can answer. Separate what is observed from what is assumed and what is still unknown.

Work through it

Identify who is affected, who sees the work first-hand and what has already been tried. Look for evidence that could change your initial view. A useful evaluation narrows uncertainty enough to choose a proportionate next step.

- What prompted this decision, and why now?
- Which evidence is current, relevant and direct? What does it leave out?
- Whose experience could challenge our interpretation?
- What happens if we continue as we are?
- Which uncertainty would change the choice, and how could we check it?

Capture three kinds of information

Known: the observation, source and date.
Assumed: the belief and why it seems plausible.
Unknown: what is missing, whether it matters and who can check it.

Carry forward
A short situation statement, the credible options, and the uncertainties that affect the decision. If a critical fact is missing, identify the check and owner before committing.

Watch for: collecting more information without asking whether it can change the decision. Stop researching when the next useful step is a bounded test.

Define

What outcome matters, and what will we choose to do?

Turn your evaluation into a direction people can act on. Describe the change you want to see, the people it should help and the trade-off you are prepared to make. Name the person accountable for the outcome.

Work through it

Compare credible options, including maintaining the current approach. Agree the criteria before picking the favourite: customer value, commercial contribution, effort, reversibility and consequences may matter differently in each case.

- What outcome are we trying to improve, for whom and by when?
- What are we deliberately leaving outside the scope?
- Which option best fits the evidence and our priorities?
- What would indicate progress, and what baseline will we compare against?
- Who owns the outcome, and what is the first practical action?

Write a decision statement

We will [action] for [audience or situation] to achieve [outcome]. We chose it because [evidence and trade-off]. [Owner] will begin with [next step]. We will review [measure or observation] at [date or trigger].

Carry forward
The chosen direction, why it was chosen, an accountable owner and a way to recognise progress. Record important alternatives so later reviewers understand the reasoning.

Watch for: treating an activity as the outcome. Launching a tool is an activity; helping a team complete a task more reliably is an outcome.

Govern

Who can decide, what needs checking, and when do we pause?

Good governance gives people room to act within clear boundaries. Make checks specific to the decision and its consequences. The objective is to handle routine work confidently and direct attention to exceptions that warrant it.

Agree the operating conditions

Name who makes the decision, who carries out the work and whose input is needed. Set limits that fit the situation: spending authority, accuracy, customer commitments, personal data, contractual obligations or other relevant constraints.

- What can the owner proceed with independently?
- Which facts or commitments need another person to verify?
- What would require escalation, a pause or a change in direction?
- Who receives that escalation, and how quickly must they respond?
- What record is enough to explain what was decided and why?

Make a boundary usable

Replace “seek approval where appropriate” with a specific condition and contact. For example: “The owner can adjust the trial workflow within the agreed scope. Changes to customer commitments go to the commercial lead before implementation.”

Carry forward
Decision rights, proportionate checks, clear escalation triggers and a review point. If a reviewer is unavailable, agree the fallback rather than leaving ownership unclear.

Watch for: a growing approval chain with no clear purpose. For every check, ask what it protects, who performs it and when it can be simplified.

Elevate

What will we do, learn and change?

Put the decision into practice. Decide how much to commit now and what you want to learn before expanding it. Review the result against the original outcome and the conditions under which the work took place.

Work through it

Give the first action an owner and a date. Capture the baseline before acting where feasible. Review what happened, not only what was intended. Ask the people doing and receiving the work what changed for them.

- What is the smallest useful action that can advance the outcome?
- What evidence would support continuing, adapting or stopping?
- What changed because of our action, and what may have changed for other reasons?
- What did the team learn that should alter the next decision?
- What can be reused, and who needs to understand it?

Close the loop

At the review, record the result, the interpretation and the next action separately. If new evidence changes the situation, return to Evaluate. If priorities change, revisit Define. If the boundaries no longer fit, revisit Govern.

Carry forward
An explicit decision to continue, adapt or stop; a named next action; and learning others can use. Update the working practice or brief, not just the presentation about it.

Watch for: declaring success because the work launched or a number improved. Compare with the baseline, consider other influences and be clear about what remains uncertain.

A message about a change in direction

A team is moving a planned launch to allow more preparation.

Illustrative scenario: the details below show how to use EDGE. They are not a report of an actual client or employer engagement. The immediate task is a message to the team, not a full launch review.

Evaluate

Confirm what has changed and who knows. The original launch date is agreed; the revised date is not. Some teams have already made plans. Check the reason for the change and which commitments need separate follow-up.

Define

The message should explain the change, acknowledge its impact and tell people what to do next. The launch owner will communicate the confirmed decision and give a date for the next update, rather than presenting an unconfirmed date as settled.

Govern

Verify the facts with the launch owner. Check whether any customer commitments or confidential details require separate handling. Make one person responsible for the update and identify where questions should go.

Elevate

Send the message, review questions and follow up on misunderstandings. If several people interpret the next step differently, improve the instruction rather than repeating the original wording.

Illustrative message

We are moving the planned launch to allow more preparation. Please pause new commitments against the original date and flag any existing commitments to the launch owner. We will confirm the revised plan in Thursday’s team update. I know this affects work already under way; bring any dependencies or questions to that discussion.

What carried through: the unconfirmed date identified in Evaluate became a clear update commitment in Define, a fact check in Govern and a question to resolve in Elevate.

A shared process across two markets

A team is considering one customer onboarding process.

Illustrative scenario: a business wants a more consistent onboarding experience in two markets. The numbers and conditions below are proposed trial choices, not claimed results or universal targets.

Evaluate

Map the existing handoffs with both local teams. Separate shared needs from differences in language, contracts and customer expectations. Check where customers wait and whether local workarounds solve a real requirement.

Define

Choose a shared core with documented local variations. Trial it with one team in each market for four weeks. The desired outcome is clearer ownership and fewer avoidable handoffs. Record current completion times and rework before the trial; agree success criteria with the teams.

Govern

Name one accountable process owner and a local lead in each market. Confirm customer commitments and relevant data-handling requirements before the trial. Local leads can change explanatory wording; changes to required information or commitments need review by the appropriate owner.

Elevate

Review weekly with the trial teams. Compare completion times, rework and customer feedback with the baseline. Check whether case complexity changed. At four weeks, decide whether to extend, adapt or stop, then document useful local variations.

A practical pause trigger
Pause the affected part of the trial if a required customer or data-handling commitment cannot be met. Escalate to the named owner, identify the correction and agree the conditions for restarting.

The lesson: consistency can come from a common outcome and clear ownership while execution respects local context.

Your EDGE decision worksheet

Use one page for the decision you are facing now.

Type into the fields below in a PDF reader that supports forms, or print this page. Keep answers short. Refer to supporting evidence where needed.

Decision and accountable owner

EVALUATE | Evidence, assumptions and important unknowns

DEFINE | Outcome, chosen direction and first step

GOVERN | Authority, checks and pause or escalation triggers

ELEVATE | Action, measure and review date

AT REVIEW | What happened and what we will change

Use EDGE with a team

Bring one real decision and leave with an owner and a next step.

A useful session should resolve something. Share the decision question and essential evidence beforehand. Invite the people who own the outcome and the people who understand the work, including local perspectives where relevant.

Choose the depth

A routine communication: a short individual check may be enough.
A reversible team decision: use a brief discussion and the one-page worksheet.
A consequential initiative: involve the relevant functions, evidence and specialists. Set staged review points rather than forcing closure in one meeting.

Facilitate the discussion

Move through the four pillars in order. Ask participants to distinguish facts from interpretations. Let people identify uncertainties before discussing preferred solutions. Capture the rationale, boundaries and next action in one shared record.

Keep disagreement useful

Ask which assumption explains different views. If it can be tested, assign the check. If it reflects different priorities, make the trade-off explicit and refer it to the decision owner. Record material dissent where it could matter later.

Before the meeting ends
Can everyone explain the decision? Does the owner know what they can do now? Is the first action scheduled? Is there a review date or trigger? If any answer is unclear, resolve it before dispersing.

The worksheet is a working aid. Add detail only when it improves the decision or helps someone act. A longer document is not evidence of better thinking.

Practical tools and human judgement

Use AI to widen the thinking while keeping responsibility clear.

I have created tools on democratising.ai to help people apply EDGE to specific situations. You can enter through the tool that matches your immediate need. Bring the context, outcome and relevant boundaries from the framework with you.

EDGE working brief

Carry evidence, choices, responsibilities and learning through all four pillars. Work independently or request optional AI suggestions.

Before You Send

Review a message and compare a suggested revision with your original. Choose what to use and verify important claims.

EDGE Practice

Rehearse a conversation, negotiation or board discussion. The counterpart is fictional; a simulation is not a prediction.

Brand and Content

Connect your brand brief, content planning and message review. Choose which context to carry forward and check the result.

A useful briefing prompt

The decision is [question]. The intended outcome is [outcome]. We know [evidence] and are assuming [assumptions]. The boundaries are [constraints]. Help me identify alternatives and questions to check. Separate evidence from speculation and do not invent missing facts.

Use only information you are authorised to share with the selected tool. Review its output yourself and verify important claims. Browse the current collection at democratising.ai/tools.

Make the next decision better

The value of EDGE lies in what changes in the work.

Use a few measures tied to the purpose of the decision. A communication might be assessed through clarity of follow-up and completion of the requested action. An operating change might be assessed through customer experience, rework, delivery time or commercial contribution.

Review the decision as well as the result

A good result can follow weak reasoning, and a well-reasoned choice can meet changed conditions. Ask what was known at the time, whether the boundaries were appropriate and which new information should alter the next decision. Avoid attributing every improvement to the framework.

- Continue when the evidence supports the chosen direction and the conditions still hold.
- Adapt when the outcome matters but the approach or assumptions need to change.
- Stop when the rationale no longer holds or the consequences cannot be managed within agreed boundaries.

About the framework

EDGE was created by Adrian Watkins, a Singapore-based commercial and operating leader whose work spans business transformation, growth, integration and governance across markets. His independent portfolio applies AI transformation to publishing and data workflows, separate from his executive responsibilities. The framework structures thinking and action. DARE, his shared publishing and data platform, supports the services built through democratising.ai.

Keep these links to hand

Framework and current guidance: adrianwatkins.com/edge
Practical tools: democratising.ai/tools
Questions and conversations: adrianwatkins.com/contact

This paper presents the author's practical method and illustrative applications. It does not report a controlled evaluation or claim a guaranteed improvement. The timing and scope of any application should reflect the decision.

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AI transformation in a service team

Improve the work before expanding the technology.

Illustrative scenario, not a reported client or employer engagement. A service team is considering AI assistance for part of its customer workflow. The aim is more reliable service, not simply more use of AI.

Evaluate

Understand where work stalls, what customers need and whether AI can help. Establish the current cost, turnaround time and quality before choosing a tool. Ask the people doing the work where judgement or local context matters.

Define

Choose one workflow and a measurable outcome. Agree what the team will do differently, the training it needs and the conditions for a useful pilot. Compare AI assistance with a simpler process change before committing.

Govern

Assign an accountable owner, set data and review boundaries, and agree when people must step in. Keep a workable fallback if the new process fails. Make responsibility for customer commitments explicit.

Elevate

Compare results with the starting point, listen to the team and customers, and improve the process before extending it. Adoption and reliable service matter as much as the output of the tool.

The business question

Has the change made the work more useful and reliable, at an acceptable cost? If not, adapt the workflow or stop the pilot. A successful demonstration alone does not answer that question.

EDGE remains a broader business framework. The same sequence supports integration, market entry, team priorities and everyday decisions, whether AI is involved or not.